

General Knowledge

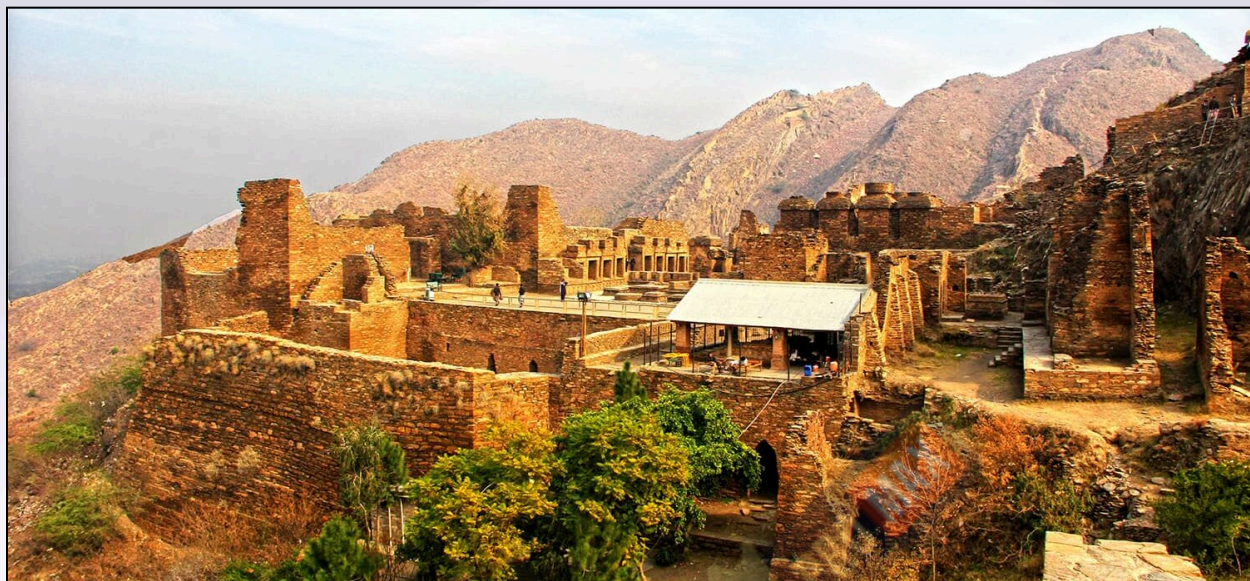
Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Sakas And Parthians



Post Maurya - Sakas And Parthians



Central Asian Contacts (200 BCE – Early CE)

- After the decline of the Mauryan Empire, several Central Asian dynasties such as **Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, and Kushanas** replaced the Mauryan rulers in **north-western India**.
- These dynasties introduced new elements in **politics, trade, religion, art, and architecture**.
- The interaction with **Central Asia** enriched Indian culture, making it a melting pot of various traditions and ideas.
- Central Asian rulers integrated with Indian society by **adopting local customs, languages, and religions**, creating a profound impact on Indian civilization.

Indo-Greeks (Bactrian Greeks)

- The **Indo-Greeks** were the first to invade India from Central Asia around **200 BCE**. They were originally Greek rulers from **Bactria** (modern-day Afghanistan).
- The **weakness of the Seleucid Empire** and the **pressure from the Scythian tribes** forced them to expand into India.

- They **occupied north-west India** and extended their influence up to **Ayodhya** and **Pataliputra**.

Ruler	Details and Contributions
Demetrius	Invaded India around 190 BCE, capturing north-western India. Engaged with Pushyamitra Shunga in battles. His conquests extended south of the Hindukush mountains.
Menander (Milinda)	Ruled from Sakala (modern Sialkot). Known for his conversion to Buddhism after discussions with Nagasena (Milindapanho). Expanded his empire to the Ganga-Yamuna doab. Famous for issuing large numbers of coins.
Hermaius	Last Indo-Greek ruler. Defeated by the Parthians, ending Greek rule in Bactria and parts of India. Greek control in northwest India declined over time, making way for Shaka and Parthian rule.

Shakas (Scythians)

- The **Shakas** were originally a **nomadic tribe from Central Asia**, driven towards India due to **wars with the Chinese and other tribes**.
- They settled in various parts of **India** after being displaced by the **Yuezhi and other Central Asian groups**.
- **Shakas controlled vast territories**, including parts of **Gujarat, Punjab, Mathura, and the Deccan**.

Political History of the Shakas

Branch	Region	Prominent Ruler	Capital	Key Contributions
1st Branch	Afghanistan	Vonones, Spalirises	-	Established initial presence in the north-west.

2nd Branch	Punjab	Maues	Taxila	Strengthened the foothold in Punjab.
3rd Branch	Mathura	Azilises	Mathura	Ruled for nearly 2 centuries.
4th Branch	Gujarat and Western India	Rudradaman I	Ujjain	Expanded power, issued Sanskrit inscriptions , and repaired Sudarshana Lake.
5th Branch	Upper Deccan (Andhra and Maharashtra)	-	-	Established regional rule in the Deccan.

Prominent Shaka Rulers and Their Contributions

1. Maues (Moga)

- Ruled Punjab and Gandhara regions around the **1st century BCE**.
- Issued **coins** depicting **Greek deities** such as Zeus and Athena.
- Adopted **Hellenistic governance practices** and supported **Buddhism**.

2. Azilises

- Strengthened Shaka's control over **Mathura**.
- Continued the **minting of bilingual coins** following Indo-Greek traditions.

3. Rudradaman I (130-150 CE)

- The most powerful Shaka ruler.
- **Expanded territories** in Gujarat, Sindh, Kutch, Kathiawar, and parts of the Deccan.
- **Defeated Satavahana kings** and consolidated power over **Konkan and Malwa**.
- Issued the **first long Sanskrit inscription** (Girnar Rock Inscription).
- Repaired the **Sudarshana Lake** in Kathiawar, demonstrating his concern for public welfare.
- Promoted the **Sanskrit language and culture** despite his Central Asian origins.

4. Chastana

- Established the **Western Kshatrapa dynasty** in **Ujjain**.
- His successors ruled parts of **Malwa and Gujarat** for several generations.



Governance and Administration

- The **Shakas** introduced the **satrap system**, dividing the empire into smaller regions known as **satrapies**.
- **Satraps (governors)** were appointed to manage local governance, ensuring effective control over distant regions.
- **Military governance** was a hallmark of the Shaka rule, inherited from the Indo-Greeks.
- They **minted coins** in large quantities, using **bilingual inscriptions** (Greek and Prakrit) to ensure administrative coherence.

Administrative Structure

Title	Role
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Satrap	Military governors managed provinces.
Kshatrapa	Junior satrap with delegated responsibilities.
Mahasenapati	The supreme commander of military forces.
Raja	Regional king responsible for governance.

Society and Culture under Shaka Rule

- **Cultural Assimilation:**
 - Despite their Central Asian origin, the **Shakas integrated into Indian society** over time.
 - They embraced **Indian customs and religions**, such as **Hinduism and Buddhism**.
- **Intermarriage and Social Integration:**
 - **Intermarriages** between Shakas and local rulers were common (e.g., Rudradaman's marriage alliance with the Satavahanas).
 - Shakas were gradually absorbed into the **Kshatriya (warrior) class** in Indian society.
 - **Manusmriti** mentions that the Shakas were considered **fallen Kshatriyas** who lost their original status.
- **Religious Influence:**
 - Many **Shaka rulers** adopted **Buddhism**, while others patronized **Hindu deities** like **Shiva and Vishnu**.
 - The **Girnar inscription of Rudradaman** reflects a blend of **Hindu values** with Central Asian traditions.

Military and Conquests

1. **Superior Cavalry Tactics:**
 - Shakas introduced **advanced cavalry techniques** with **riding horses, saddles, and reins**.
 - They also popularized the use of **long coats, trousers, and boots**, making them more effective in warfare.

2. Wars and Expansion:

- **Rudradaman I** defeated the **Satavahana** rulers and expanded the Shaka kingdom.
- Shakas engaged in continuous conflict with **local Indian dynasties** and **other foreign rulers** like the Parthians and Kushanas.

Religion under Shakas

Religion	Key Influence and Practices
Hinduism	Worshipped Shiva and Vishnu . Patronized Vaishnavism .
Buddhism	Some rulers, like Maues, embraced Buddhism and supported Buddhist monasteries .
Religious Tolerance	Shakas promoted religious harmony and accepted both Hindu and Buddhist practices .

Decline of the Shakas

- **Rise of Local Dynasties:** The **Satavahanas** and **Guptas** launched campaigns to drive the Shakas out of their territories.
- **Defeat by Vikramaditya:** Around **58 BCE**, a local ruler known as **Vikramaditya** defeated the Shakas and established the **Vikram Samvat era**.
- **Absorption by Kushanas:** The **Kushanas** eventually displaced the Shakas in **north-western India**.

Parthians (Pahlavas)

- The **Parthians** originally came from **Iran and Central Asia**.
- They are mentioned in **ancient Sanskrit texts** along with the **Shakas** as "Shaka-Pahlavas".
- The Parthians established their presence in **north-western India** following the decline of the **Indo-Greek** rule and alongside the **Shaka domination**.
- Though their political control was limited, the **Parthians integrated into Indian society** over time and promoted **Indian religions and art**.



Political History of the Parthians

Ruler	Period	Region of Rule	Achievements and Contributions
Vonones	1st century BCE	Afghanistan	Established initial control over Afghanistan after the Greek decline.
Spalirises	1st century BCE	Gandhara and Taxila	Strengthened Parthian foothold in north-western India.
Maues (Moga)	1st century CE	Punjab	A powerful ruler supported Buddhism and issued coins with Greek symbols .
Gondophernes	19-45 CE	Gandhara and Taxila	Converted to Christianity by St. Thomas; a significant patron of Buddhism and builder of stupas.
Abdagases	1st century CE	North-western India	Succeeded Gondophernes, but lost much of the territory to the Kushanas .

Gondophernes and His Legacy

- **Gondophernes** was the most **prominent Parthian ruler**.
- **Capital:** His rule centered around **Taxila** in modern Pakistan.
- **Religion:** Converted to **Christianity** under the influence of **St. Thomas**, an apostle who came to India to spread Christianity.
- **Contributions to Buddhism:** Patronized **Buddhist monasteries** and built stupas.
- **Coins and Inscriptions:** Issued coins with **Greek legends** and **Indian symbols**, showing a blend of cultures.
- **Takht-i-Bahi Inscription:** Found near **Mardan**, this inscription from 45 CE provides valuable information about his reign.

Religion and Society under the Parthians

Religion	Influence and Patronage
Christianity	Gondophernes was converted by St. Thomas , marking one of the earliest Christian influences in India.
Buddhism	Several Parthian rulers supported Buddhist monasteries and stupas .
Hinduism	Parthians also worshipped local Hindu deities and followed Indian customs .

- **Social Integration:**
 - The Parthians **assimilated into Indian society** over time.
 - **Intermarriage** between Parthians and local Indian rulers was common.
 - **Manusmriti** refers to the **Parthians and Shakas** as **fallen Kshatriyas**, indicating their gradual absorption into Indian society.

Decline of the Parthians

- **Invasions by the Kushanas:**
 - The **Kushanas displaced the Parthians** from their territories in **north-western India**.
 - The last Parthian rulers were gradually absorbed into **Kushan governance**.

- **Assimilation into Indian Society:**

- Over time, the Parthians **lost their distinct identity** and became a part of **Indian culture and society**.

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